

intervene and help set up a coordination committee. As SAD's key interlocutor with BJP, he now faces the onerous task of keeping coalition relations on an even keel in the face of the saffron party's growing demand for its pound of flesh. It is for the first time in their coalition history that the party is dependent on BJP in terms of legislative strength—a reality that the Akalis haven't reconciled with yet. "As the BJP is not willing to play second fiddle, their coordination is sans cordiality," says veteran BJP leader Balramji Dass Tandon.

The BJP has also been feeling uneasy with Sukhbir's dogged efforts to cultivate an urban base as part of his

across as a ruler in a hurry. By combining his corporate finesse with a hands-on approach, he is pushing an ambitious road map to bolster the state's infrastructure and economy. Last month, he wowed a galaxy of Punjabi NRIs with a Power-Point presentation on his vision for the state.

Topping his priorities are big ticket projects to make Punjab power surplus with additional generation of 5,000 MW by 2010, a Rs 3,000-crore canal remodelling plan to enhance foodgrain productivity, building of two international airports at Mohali and Bhatinda, a Metro rail in Ludhiana, and a network of expressways and flyovers



HANDS-ON: Sukhbir with wife Harsimrat (left) and mother Surinder Kaur

BADAL INC

The clan controls all the key levers of the Government

Parkash Singh Badal: Chief Minister and patron of the Shiromani Akali Dal

Sukhbir Singh Badal (son): President of Shiromani Akali Dal and MP from Faridkot

Manpreet Singh Badal (Nephew): Finance Minister

Adesh Partap Singh (son-in-law): Minister of Excise and Taxation

Bikramjit Singh Majithia (brother-in-law of Sukhbir): Minister for Public Health and Information and Public Relations

Janmeja Singh Sekhon (a close kin of Badal): Irrigation Minister

UNLIKE HIS FATHER'S STODGY STYLE OF GOVERNANCE, SUKHBIR IS A MAN IN A HURRY, USING CORPORATE PRACTICES TO PUSH HIS ROADMAP TO BOLSTER PUNJAB'S INFRASTRUCTURE AND ECONOMY

agenda to broadbase SAD beyond the Panthic constituency. In the corporation elections last year, BJP had protested SAD's attempt to stake claim to the Mayor's post in Amritsar and Jalandhar by manoeuvring defections. The BJP has also not taken favourably to Sukhbir's announcements to set up boards representing business and industry—which form the saffron party's votebank. Then, there is a sticky issue of subsidies on which both the partners have strong views. While the BJP is pushing for rollback on all freebies, including free power to farmers as a panacea to the state's poor fiscal health, SAD is resisting such steps—a line Sukhbir strongly backs.

Unlike his father's stodgy style of governance, he comes

across the state. Of all places Bhatinda has been getting his special attention and is touted as a future model city with Rs 400 crore investment in the pipeline for upgradation of infrastructure, including a world-class cricket stadium. Many view the largesse as his plan to nurture Bhatinda as his future constituency as his home turf Faridkot stands reserved under the delimitation.

Sukhbir has kickstarted his campaign by signing a number of MOUs and expediting land acquisition and official clearances. "People think that I am talking too big but all the projects would soon be a reality and radically transform the state," he says. His political opponents dismiss him as a dream merchant and point to the state's sorry fiscal health.